senior CCP Central Committee member Yang Shangkun as part of an ‘anti-Party clique’.

The country was thrown into turmoil as purges, mass meetings, and even killings of real and imaginary opponents to Mao became daily occurrences. Youthful and militant Red Guards roamed the countryside, terrorizing the population and destroying temples and anything else that could remind the people of pre-revolutionary days. Among those in a higher position to be humiliated in public and purged was Liu Shaoqi, once the second-most powerful man in the country after Mao. Deng Xiaoping was also targeted, purged, and sent to work as a regular worker at a tractor factory in Jiangxi province. His son, Deng Pufang, was tortured and thrown out of a window of a four-storey building. He became a paraplegic, bound for life to a wheelchair.

One of the masterminds behind the purges was Kang Sheng, the psychopathic opium addict who had played an important role in the CCP’s intelligence network since the 1930s. Sidney Rittenberg, an American who was close to Mao and the entire leadership, described him as ‘dark, devious and sinister’.[51] Calling India’s Menon a ‘Rasputin’ was a clear exaggeration, but Kang Sheng certainly did live up to that epithet. According to Rittenberg, Kang Sheng was ‘always holding something back, besides bragging about his ability to spot foreign agents…[he] carried himself as if he was wearing an invisible monocle surveying others with a superior and suspicious gaze.’[52]

Even the supposed ‘moderate’ Zhou Enlai, who Nehru once had trusted, was part of the leadership that unleashed a reign of terror in China. He made sure that the state machinery was functioning reasonably well during the years of upheaval. But he kept on the defensive, guarding his political backside, being challenged by Mao’s vicious wife Jiang Qing. To make sure he was on the winning side during the Cultural Revolution, Zhou signed off on the documents used to expel Liu Shaoqi from the CCP in October 1968.[53] Rather than being an astute statesman, Zhou was the ultimate manipulator and opportunist.

Despite the few years of uncertainty after the death of Nehru, Indian politics remained, by comparison, a lot calmer than China’s, though the 1962 War led India to also expand, modernize, and rearm all branches of its armed forces. For the defence of the north, new mountain divisions were